



BIRLA INSTITUTE OF TECHNOLOGY AND SCIENCE, Pilani
Pilani Campus
AUGS/ AGSR Division

FIRST SEMESTER 2026-27
COURSE HANDOUT

Date: 31.07.2027

In addition to part I (General Handout for all courses appended to the Timetable) this portion gives further specific details regarding the course.

Course No : GS F313
Course Title : Marxian Thought
Instructor-in-Charge : Dr. Paul Mathew

1. Course Description: This course aims to introduce undergraduate students to key concepts of Marxist theory. After beginning with a brief survey of the dominant narratives on inequality and exploitation, students will be introduced to the critique of bourgeois history developed by Marx and Engels, particularly in their writings on dialectical and historical materialism. In order to get a clearer view of how capitalism produces surplus value, Marx's Labor Theory of Value and other related concepts will be read and discussed. At regular intervals, this conceptual framework will be applied to analyze cultural texts (films, advertisements, popular culture etc.) in order to develop analytical skills that surpass conventional wisdom in the study of social and economic structures.

2. Scope and Objective of the Course: Considering that Marxist theory and practice is a vast field, this course has limited itself to some of the central concepts and questions that are timely and relevant to students in these modern times [Refer to the Modules]. The primary objective is to understand the Marxist critique of capitalism, and based on that understanding, examine if it is possible to forge another kind of society, more egalitarian and without fundamentally exploitative structures.

3. Primary Text and Viewing Material:

Selections from these books and viewing material will be used based on the requirements of the class.

- o *A Reader's Guide to Marx's Capital* - Joseph Choonara
- o *Chapters from Yanis Varoufakis*
- o *Selected Readings from Ha-Joon Chang*

Film Clippings for Class Discussion: *Mandi*, Yashowardhan Mishra (2019); *Rang de Basanti* (2006); *Bread and Roses*, Ken Loach (2000); *The Wind that Shakes the Barley*, Ken Loach (2006); *Nae Pasaran*, Felipe Bustos Sierra (2018)



5. Course Plan:

Class No	Lecture Session	Reference	Learning outcomes
1-4	Why Marxism? An introduction to the many theories and narratives that claim to explain inequality in society. Relevance of Karl Marx in the 21st century.	“Why so much Inequality?” – Yanis Varoufakis Critique of Malthusian claims of overpopulation - “Are there just too many of us?” - Manali Chakrabarti “All in the genes?” - Richard Lewontin	Here the course begins with key questions about the roots of inequality in modern industrial society and arrives at some answers. Primarily this involves being able to identify gaps and problems in the dominant discourse around inequality.
5-8	Dialectics and Historical Materialism Brief overview of the history of class society from a Marxist perspective and the marxist method of analysis. Modes and relations of production transition from primitive to feudal society and then to industrial capitalism.	What is a “Mode of Production”? - Paul Cockshott Agrarian Origins of Capitalism - <i>The Origins of Capitalism</i> by Ellen Meiksins Wood Part 1 - Man's Worldly Goods - Leo Huberman The History Book – Jannik Hastrup - 1974 Chapter 2 - Structure and Action - Alex Callinicos	Here we directly enter the mature theoretical framework which Marx had developed to explain the history of class society and its recurrent feature of social inequality. His critique of Hegel is crucial to understand dialectical materialism.
9-18	Marx's Labour Theory of Value What creates value? Use Value – Exchange Value – Surplus Value Cooperation & development of Machinery General law of capitalist accumulation	Ch 1 & 2, from <i>The Value of Everything: Making and Taking in the Global Economy</i>, by Mariana Mazzucato A Reader's Guide to Marx's Capital - Choonara (pages 18-113) Excerpt from Red Rosa – biography of Rosa Luxembourg	Here we try to grasp the specific ways in which surplus value is extracted in a capitalist mode of production and the nature of the power relationship embedded therein.
19-21	Fetishism of the Commodity Alienation Marxist Crisis Theories Tendency for Fall in the Rate of Profit Counteracting Factors	Mandi – Yashowardhan Mishra (2019) Farmer's first taste of chocolate The Cause of Depressions - Michael Roberts Counteracting Factors (to TFRP) - Marx	One of the major consequences of capitalist social organization is the rise of the <i>commodity form</i> as a dominant form of social metabolism – Fetishism of the commodity and the alienation it produces are quite relevant to understanding many social ills, including in contemporary society.



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22-26	Critique of Neoclassical and Neoliberal Ideology 1. Free trade 2. Capitalist Efficiency 3. Self-Interest 4. Say's Law 5. Invisible Hand of the Market 6. Rational Consumer 7. Marginal Utility	Strange History of the Economic Agent - by Duncan K Foley Is Free Trade Always the Answer? - Ha Joon Chang Revisiting Inequality through 'Capitalist Hierarchy' - What do Bosses Do? - Stephen Marglin On the Margins - Foley	Certain ideologies pervade modern political and economic thought, some inherited from classical philosophy, some new. Here we examine the origin, essence and validity of these claims/concepts.
27-30	Imperialism Monopoly Capitalism - Why imperialism survives even after decolonization.	Imperialism, the Highest Stage of Capitalism - VI Lenin The Global Commodity - John Smith Ref; Samir Amin, Baran, Sweezy	One of the major consequences of capitalist social organization is the rise of the <i>commodity form</i> as a dominant form of social metabolism – Fetishism of the commodity and the alienation it produces are quite relevant to understanding many social ills, including in contemporary society.
31-36	What is Socialism and Communism? Discussion on Violence Socialism Now - Case Study on China	The Communist Manifesto - Marx & Engels (page 31-84) Revolution and the Question of Violence; Ch 2 & 8 – Why Marx Was Right - Terry Eagleton Selected Works of Mao-Tse-Tung (selected paragraphs will be discussed in class) “Excerpts From Talks Given In Wuchang, Shenzhen, Zhuhai and Shanghai” - Deng Xiaoping	Comprehend class struggle going beyond popular misconceptions and grasp the historical nature of this process. In addition, the aim is to develop clarity in thinking about the history of different forms of violence and its role in the liberation and oppression of people.
37-40	Building Alternatives - Reorganizing work and society	<i>Can we democratize work?</i> - “Contradictions of Democracy in a Workers’ Cooperative” – Varman & Chakrabarti <i>How can capitalism be overturned?</i> “What is to be Done” - Lenin Workers Co-ops - Cooperation Jackson	Finally, is Marxism relevant today and if so, why? Is it true that capitalism is increasing the median wages of people across the world? Here, we address the modern forms of capitalism and locate how Marx's ideas continue to hold relevance in theoretically understanding these phenomena and offering a way beyond these systems.



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6. Evaluation Scheme:

Component	Duration	Weightage (%)	Date & Time	Nature of component (Close Book/ Open Book)
Mid-Semester Test	90 mins	30	06/10/2026 FN1	Closed Book
In Class Assignment	50 mins	20	Declared in Advance	Closed Book
Surprise Quiz	15 mins	5	Declared in Class	Closed Book
Surprise Quiz	15 mins	5	Declared in Class	Closed Book
Comprehensive Examination	180 mins	40	05/12/2026 FN	Open Book

7. Chamber Consultation Hour: Friday 2-3pm; 6170-D, HSS Department.

8. Notices: All notices and updates will be shared on the google classroom created for the course.

9. Make-up Policy: Permitted at the discretion of the instructor-in-charge, and only in emergencies or significant unforeseen circumstances.

10. Note (if any): Addition/substitution of viewing or reading material can be discussed in class. Students are expected to attend classes regularly and be familiar with the required readings for each class as informed via google classroom notifications. Kindly note that evaluative components will give substantial stress to class discussions and unique material introduced only in the classroom.

Prof. Paul Mathew
Instructor-in-Charge
Course No. GS F313